

System prompt / instructions

STRONG attention

Retrieved documents, examples

... more middle content ...

WEAKEST attention

... and more ...

Conversation history

The actual question / task

STRONG attention

Model's own output grows here (and eats the same budget)

"Lost in the middle": recall is best at the edges
of the window and worst in the middle.

Design rule — put instructions at the top,
the task at the bottom, and keep the middle short.